time of the Swadeshi movement and employed well over 1,500 workers. Using an engine of 1,100 horsepower, it turned out some 2,500 tons of yarn annually.

The Harveys managed Madura and Company which, as we noted above, was the Tuticorin Agents of BI. (Madura and Company was also Tuticorin Agents for two other liners.) Agencies apart, they also held other interests and powers. For instance, Madura and Company was Lloyd's Agents at Nagapattinam, and Sub-Agent at Tuticorin.[62] Despite being spread out across the southern districts, the Harveys were headquartered in Tuticorin—just right for friction to develop with SSNCo.

At the time of our story, the BI Agency at Tuticorin was manned by Eric Chapman and Newton. What their official designations were is not clear with newspaper reports referring to them variously as agents and managers —and therefore employees of the Harveys. Chapman is described as a forty-four-year-old merchant as well as an agent of BI who had been living in Tuticorin off and on from 1901. Chapman had been away for about a year prior to mid-February 1908, and therefore we may surmise that Newton was running the show during this time.[63]

## The Port Develops

Tuticorin, as part of the Pearl Fishery Coast, with its traditional seafaring and fishing community of Paravars has a unique place in south India's maritime history. The shifting coastline impacted the ports, and their fortunes changed over the centuries. Korkai, the ancient port that figured in Greek texts, receded inland by a few kilometres and is barely 20 km to Tuticorin's south. As is the other port, Kayal, that flourished subsequently. From at least the late medieval times, Tuticorin was an important centre for the building and repair of native vessels, as also a centre of the pearl and chank fishery. With the deepening of the Mannar channel, the pearl yield decreased and the quality of pearls also suffered. Tuticorin's modern history dates back to 1540 when the Portuguese settled there and fortified it. The Dutch captured it in 1658 and held it for nearly a century and a half. The